



ASK A DOCTOR

Why are varicose veins common in pregnancy and what can I do to avoid getting them? Your blood volume increases up to 30 percent, due to the added needs of your baby and your expanding body. The hormone relaxin also softens the walls of your blood vessels. The blood vessels relax and the increased blood and extra weight of the baby make you susceptible to varicose veins.

To reduce the likelihood of getting varicose veins:

- **Avoid sitting or standing in one position** for prolonged periods: walk around, move your arms as you do so to increase the blood flow in your body.
- **Exercise daily:** most forms of cardiovascular exercise will help increase blood flow. Water aerobics is a good choice since the pressure of the water helps increase blood circulation.